

Chapter 14

White supremacists' weaponization of Celtic heritage languages and language revitalization

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In response to the rise in white supremacist terrorism and hate crimes, there has been an imperative to monitor white supremacist networks. Significant linguistic scholarship has examined how white supremacists espouse linguicidal ideologies of English monolingualism and oppress users of minoritized dialects and languages. Linguists and language activists have combated this white supremacy and colonialism by promoting heritage languages and language revitalization, but little work has examined how some white supremacists appropriate and weaponize these efforts, especially with Celtic languages. This paper examines language ideologies in corpora of white supremacist speech. The findings show that some white supremacists support and learn their languages of heritage to index their white supremacy, which include minority and even endangered languages of Europe, especially those in the Celtic family.

1 Introduction

Before I proceed with my introduction, it is prudent to provide both a warning of the content and a note on my position as a scholar investigating this topic.

This paper contains uncensored quotes (with references to source material) from corpora of hate speech extracted from white supremacism, white supremacist and extremist sites, and some of these quoted examples include slurs.¹ I leave

¹There are no quotes that include the n-word in this paper.



them fully quoted so they can be viewed in context. I also do not fix any typos or grammatical errors in the quotes.

I recognize that ideologies of language quoted in this paper have traumatized countless people and communities. While I acknowledge that some may be (re)-traumatized by this hate speech, this is not my intention, but rather to expose, analyze, and fight white supremacists' ideologies on language.

Regarding my position, I am a straight white cis male of Scottish, Irish, and Welsh ancestry, whose first language is a privileged variety of American English and whose second language is Brazilian Portuguese, acquired as an adult.

As a linguist, I am a proponent of learning heritage languages and language revitalization. Indeed, some of these are major areas of research for me, including my own heritage Celtic languages. However, this paper will show how these areas are being appropriated and weaponized by white supremacists for their own purposes.

1.1 Background

There has been a rise in white supremacist terrorism and hate crimes (Byman 2022). As a consequence, there has been an imperative to monitor white supremacist networks. Scholars in various disciplines have recently embraced this imperative, especially in light of the observation that white supremacist organizations have been “zealous consumers and promoters of primary scientific literature” (Carlson et al. 2022: 445) for racist ends. Recent scholarship in different disciplines has sought to expose and counter the presence of white supremacist subcultures within their broader fields, such as in folklore (Wilson 2021), ecology (Bergman 2021), genetics (Carlson et al. 2022), among many others.

Throughout the last several decades, linguistic scholarship has examined how white supremacists espouse linguicidal ideologies of English monolingualism and oppress users of minoritized dialects and languages (Kroskrity 2021, *inter alia*). Linguists and language activists have combated this white supremacy and colonialism by promoting heritage languages and language revitalization (Hinton et al. 2018). However, very little work has examined how some white supremacists appropriate and weaponize these efforts, which is the subject of the present chapter.

There is robust literature of looking at hate speech on white supremacist websites. Daniels (1997: 37) found that:

On almost every front in which white men are presented as “warriors” they are simultaneously presented as “victims.” White men depict themselves

as victims of racial discrimination, of class oppression, and as the special victims of race, gender, and class oppression at the hands of the racial state.

Bridle (2016) conducted a critical discourse analysis on posts on Stormfront, a white supremacist forum. He focuses particularly on homophobia. He finds that despite the fact that the:

overwhelming majority of discourses and texts on Stormfront related to gay men are both negative and homophobic, [...] race takes precedence over sexual orientation, as gay men are constructed positively on the condition that they support white nationalism (p. 92).

Brindle concludes that, for example, white supremacists rank gay men above Muslims.

Yet, there has been little research that has looked at white supremacist websites as primary sources within the fields of heritage language, language endangerment, and language revitalization, other than white supremacists opposing and oppressing these efforts.

1.2 Framework

I am utilizing part of Rosa & Flores's (2017) framework of raciolinguistics, which frames "the co-naturalization of language and race as a process of raciolinguistic enregisterment, whereby linguistic and racial forms are jointly constructed as sets and rendered mutually recognizable as named languages/varieties and racial categories" (p. 631). Critical to their framework are the "continued rearticulations of colonial distinctions between Europeaness and non-Europeaness – and, by extension, whiteness and nonwhiteness" (p. 622). This is similar to how Irvine & Gal (2000: 73) discuss the "dichotomizing discourses of orientalism" which is seen in ideologies on languages, and where Europe is viewed "in opposition to a broadly defined 'East'". We will see that these are the sorts of distinctions that white supremacists seek to reinforce in what languages they find acceptable to be spoken, and even more, who is allowed to speak them.

I am also employing intersectionality (Crenshaw 1989, *inter alia*). Throughout this paper, we see how white supremacists punish every departure from the straight white cis male "native" speaker "standard," whose speech is the only kind white supremacists find acceptable.

1.2.1 Research questions

My research questions are as follows:

- (a) What languages do white supremacists view as acceptable? Which ones do they view as “for whites only”?
- (b) What are their ideologies toward language diversity, minority languages, heritage languages, language endangerment, and their revitalization?
- (c) How do they view Celtic languages?
- (d) What are the consequences of their ideologies?

This paper examines language ideologies in corpora of white supremacist and extremist speech.

1.3 Data source

I used three primary sources for my corpus analysis:

- de Gilbert et al. 2018’s *Hate Speech Dataset* (HSD)
- Kennedy et al. 2022’s *Gab Hate Corpus* (GHC)
- Metapedia²

I will address each primary source individually.

1.3.1 Hate Speech Dataset (HSD)

The HSD is a corpus of extracted text from a sample of 5,000 Stormfront posts (around 0.05% of the site), which is a major white supremacist forum and the oldest and most influential hate website (Hartzell 2020).³ HSD contains 196,571 words across 21 subforums collected between 2002 and 2017.

I am looking at this hate-filled corpus because it provides explicit insight into white supremacists’ ideologies. It implicates all posters as white supremacists or white nationalists, whereas other message boards with numerous racists (i.e.,

²www.en.metapedia.org

³Southern Poverty Law Center (2022) considers the Daily Stormer more influential recently, but to my knowledge, the one study which examines posts on the Daily Stormer (Calderón et al. 2021) has not made their corpus public.

4chan, 8chan/8kun, etc.) aren't *exclusively* defined by white supremacy. No one is going to post on a website whose banner reads "white pride world wide" unless they espouse white nationalist ideologies. Finally, according to Beirich (2014), registered users have been connected to over one hundred murders.

One important methodological note is that HSD samples posts throughout the subforums and that the samples comprise only single posts, not dialogue or conversations. Thus, the context of a given post is not always immediately clear. However, metadata in HSD provides information of which subforum each post comes from, so general themes and topics surrounding a given post can be ascertained.

It is also important to note that while Stormfront is hosted in the United States, and American white nationalists are a massive group on the website, it is very much an international venue for hate speech. In fact, the slogan on its banner shows this was always its mission. As such, the forum has many posters from all over the world (though no metadata on location exists in the corpus).

1.3.2 Gab Hate Corpus (GHC)

Gab is a social media platform with a far-right user base – a Twitter of sorts for extremists. The GHC is a corpus of extracted text from 27,551 posts (a small fraction of the millions of posts) from Gab, collected between January and October of 2018. The corpus contains 564,280 words. Like the HSD, the corpus does not preserve dialogue or conversations, but rather individual posts.

I am looking at a corpus of Gab because the platform has become a space for far-right extremists, notably white supremacists, conspiracy theorists, right-wing insurrectionist and militant types, and fascists. Because Gab explicitly refuses to moderate its platform, many extremists who were deplatformed or otherwise disaffected from other social media websites have migrated to Gab, which has become a "haven for dangerous white supremacists" according to the editors at the Southern Poverty Law Center (2019). David Duke is a major figure on this website, and it was the preferred social media platform of domestic terrorist Robert Bowers. This social media site provides real-time reactions of extremists to current events.

Nevertheless, unlike the other two data sources, Gab isn't exclusively defined by a white supremacist userbase, but it is the case that white nationalists are a principal group, and perhaps the largest. So, while the userbase of Gab isn't categorically white supremacist, unlike Stormfront, it is certainly stochastically white supremacist. A simple search of the term "Jew," "white genocide," Nazi slogans, and the n-word in GHC reveals the ubiquity of white supremacist ideology

proliferating on the site. Further, posts from GHC analyzed in this paper were chosen for their specific espousal of white nationalist and racist ideology, which is different from HSD, where all posters are implicated as white supremacists by simply being users of Stormfront. Otherwise, I characterize the posters on GHC as extremists, which is an accurate characterization of its user base.

1.3.3 Metapedia

Metapedia is a white nationalist wiki founded in Sweden. According to SPLC, Metapedia bills itself as “an alternative encyclopedia dedicated to the pro-European cultural struggle.” Metapedia has a number of articles on various languages, as well as articles on linguistics and languages. I use computational tools to scrape articles from the website.

I am examining articles on Metapedia because, as a wiki, the website provides a window into white nationalist ideologies and philosophies on a number of subjects. Metapedia has been examined in other fields for windows into racist pseudoscience (de Keulenaar et al. 2022). According to Oeberst et al. (2018), Metapedia articles tend to be short and unsourced, and de Keulenaar et al. (2019) further characterize the articles as “alternative facts.”

It is important to note that many of the articles on Metapedia are stubs and fragments, and the distribution of topics is uneven and varies greatly by language. Arnstad (2015) found the distribution of articles by languages on Metapedia seen in Table 1. All articles were scraped in November 2022.

1.3.4 Other sources

I also consulted two major databases of white supremacist terminology, symbolism, and ideologies. The first is the Anti-Defamation League’s 2022 *Glossary of Extremism and Hate Symbol Database*, which is a source that includes symbols, images, and descriptions on 214 hate symbols. The second is the Southern Poverty Law Center’s 2022 *Extremist Files*, which includes databases on 136 extremists, 72 extremist groups, and 24 ideologies.

2 Methodology and results

In this section, I explain each of the computational methodologies I employ for each of the three primary data source corpora.

Table 1: Number of articles by language on Metapedia

Language	No. of Articles
Hungarian	146,470
German	55,859
English	19,862
Swedish	10,271
Spanish	9,167
Estonian	2,692
Romanian	2,393
French	1,878
Portuguese	1,629
Slovenian	935
Norwegian	602
Dutch	412

2.1 Hate Speech Dataset

I looked at what languages white supremacists talk about. So, I used computational tools to find language keywords from posts on HSD. Using a comma separated value file of 12,697 names of dialects, languages (both current and historical), and language families pulled from lists on (the real) Wikipedia, I wrote python code that, with regular expressions (*re*) patterns (`^X.*`), searched names for languages in the corpus, including derived and inflected forms.

Note that Irish was the second most frequent language mentioned, and Celtic the most frequent mentioned family.

Next, I looked at what languages white supremacists use in their posts. It seems that moderators on Stormfront routinely police subforums and delete non-English posts, as seen in the following quote.

Gentlemen, I remember you that all the posts not in English will be deleted. Only posts in English, please!??? [...] (HSD: 14076260)⁴

As expected, the posts are overwhelmingly in English. But moderators occasionally tolerate posts in other languages. So, I identified the language of every post

⁴Every quote is provided with a numerical reference of the source corpora on HSD or GHC in parentheses, or in the case of Metapedia, the name of the article.

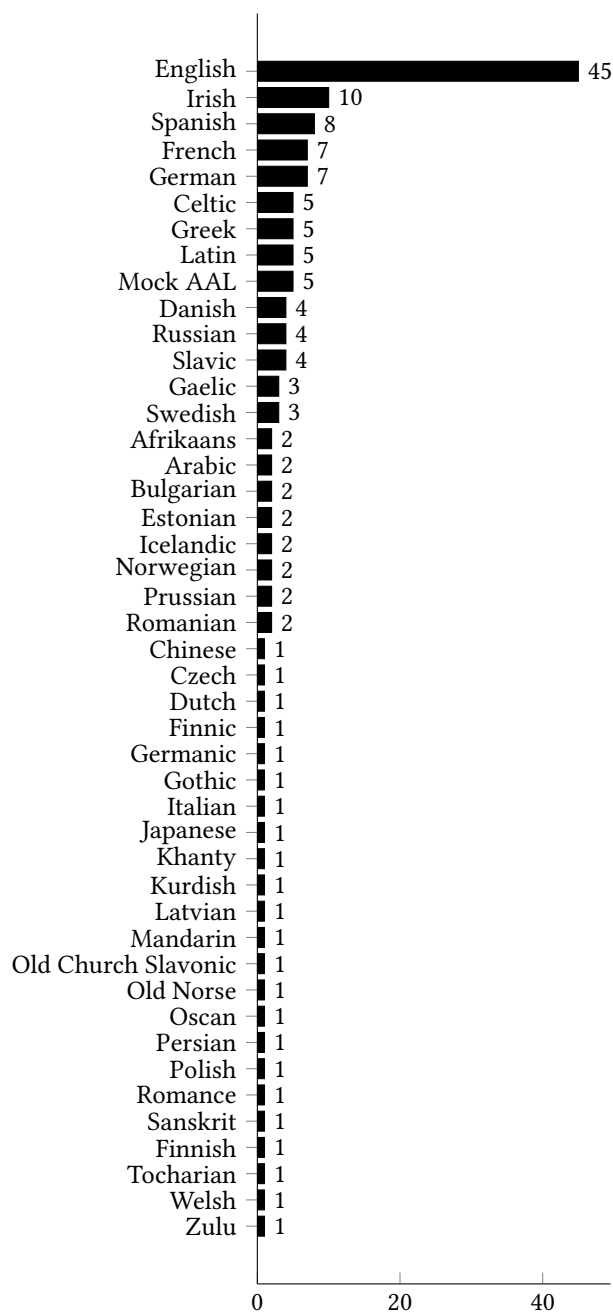


Figure 1: Frequency of the mentions of languages in HSD

using `languid.py` package (Lui & Baldwin 2012).⁵ This provides a scope of languages tolerated on Stormfront.

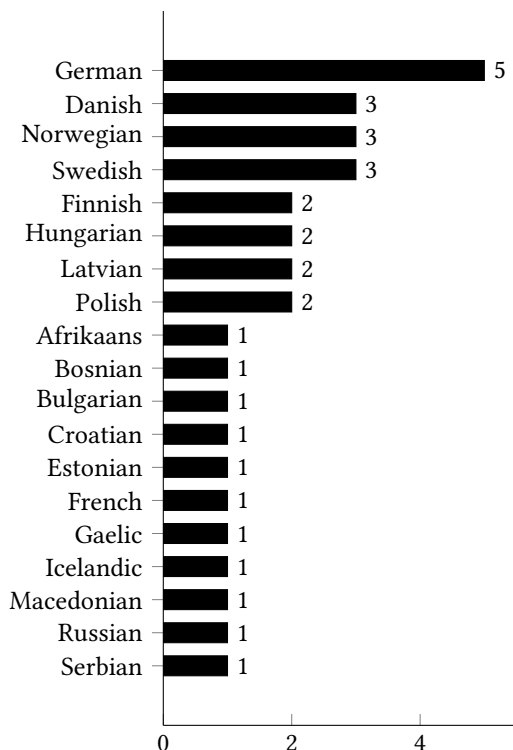


Figure 2: Frequency of posts in languages besides English on HSD

All non-English posts came from European languages (exclusively from the Germanic, Uralic, Slavic, Celtic, and Romance families). As such, Stormfront enforces English-only policies but that the universe of tolerated languages are all European or descendants from European languages. In Section 3, I return to the contents of the posts.

2.2 Gab Hate Corpus

I used the same code for examining GHC. However, as I mentioned, Gab is defined by its extremist user base, and as such, since this is a study about and not extremism more broadly, I use this code for GHC for different purposes.

⁵I removed posts that included rote Nazi slogans in German, as well as advertisements.

First, I looked at what languages are generally used on Gab. An important distinction between HSD and GHC is that the latter doesn't purge non-English posts.⁶ As a result, there are subcommunities on Gab which would be characterized as far-right groups in a number of other countries, especially those in Germany and Brazil associated with Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) and Partido Liberal (PL), respectively. Running `langid.py` revealed 174 non-English posts, about 0.63% of the entire corpus. Of those posts, 75 are in German, 59 in Portuguese, 14 in Dutch, 13 in Spanish, 9 in French, 2 in Latin, 1 in Bosnian and 1 in Romanian.

Then, I examined what Gab users, especially those who explicitly espouse white supremacist ideologies in their posts, say about languages, especially Celtic ones. I examine these along with posts from HSD in Section 3.

2.3 Metapedia

Finally, I wanted to find out what sorts of topics related to language and languages, especially those discussed in this study, are found within Metapedia articles. So, I searched for and scraped articles on Metapedia. Metapedia uses the same general API that all Wikis use. Thus, I retooled code for scraping Wikipedia articles to scrape articles on Metapedia. Specifically, I used the *requests* library for python for the Metapedia API. I performed search queries (using the *query* function) of key terms in article names, usually involving "language," "Celtic," or other related topics. Most of the articles on language feature the keyword language in the article title, and many of the title names reflect those of articles on Wikipedia, so that helped me in crafting optimal searches. During this process, I would also note hyperlinks and related articles to expand my search. Then, I scraped (using the *parse* function) HTML of articles on the website into a *json* format text output. This was conducted all behind a commercial VPN. I did this in order to avoid visiting Metapedia in my browser, so I am thus merely working with text outputted from my python code. As such, I wasn't interacting with Metapedia articles the way typical users do, but I was nevertheless able to browse and extract text from the site.

I qualitatively explore the texts retrieved from these computational tools in the subsequent sections.

⁶However, many users exhibit hostility towards those who don't post in English on Gab.

Fucking foreigner. I don't deal with people that can't speak proper English. (GHC: 20650)
if you're trying to make people stop using your app, continue to shove all these foreign language posts in our faces. I am getting tired of scrolling over incomprehensible foreign shit. (GHC: 12480)

3 Discussion

Before I discuss posts related to Celtic languages, I must first dispel the notion that because Stormfront and Gab are predominately associated with American white supremacism and extremism, that they only promote English monolingualism. The situation is far more complicated.

3.1 English-only ideologies and whiteness

To be sure, plenty of posts on HSD promote English-only ideologies, and even English supremacy.

[...] In the battle of languages English has won. (HSD: 13440452)

White supremacists discourse often involves appeals to conquest of white people over other races, and this post mirrors that for languages. Yet, posters routinely complain about their perception of how many people, largely immigrants, don't speak English.

its the same way in denver. i dont even think anybody speaks english out here anymore. i love this town but i think its time to go... (HSD: 14109242)⁷

As Stormfront is an international venue for white supremacism, the English-only ideologies are not always expressed from an American perspective, especially evident in the following quotes.

Yeah iam from Edinburgh and i when i was at secondary school my classes where full of blacks and pakis and half them could hardly speak english. (HSD: 14030845)

A British school where none of the students have English as their first language? This is the last straw, how much more will damage Europe and Western civilization these Zionists? (HSD: 14034403)

The previous quote makes explicit that anti-immigration ideologies of white supremacists are rooted in antisemitism. This is evident in their orientalist discourses towards a school with second language speakers. Moreover, there is a reference to the great replacement conspiracy theory of Jews damaging "Europe"

⁷As noted above, I do not correct spelling or punctuation errors in quotes from postings, nor do I censor offensive language. I present them here verbatim.

and “Western Civilization” through the education of immigrants, especially those from outside Europe and the West.

Some posters put forward notions that immigrant students receive more attention than non-immigrants, without any evidence.

Irish pupils are getting less teacher time too because they’re so busy helping the immigrant children get up to date. (HSD: 13858717)

Their solutions often include repeating oppressive histories, as seen in the following posts.

I agree. And that goes for Eastern Europeans and Asians as well. All schools in Ireland should be segregated. If teachers have to focus extra attention on foreigners because they cannot speak English properly, it will be the indigenous Irish students who will suffer. (HSD: 13855938)

they sent many of the irish immigrants over hundreds of years ago during one of the first ever drafts I beleive. So lets do it to the beaners. (HSD: 14414751)

White supremacists on HSD cite these oppressive histories toward the Irish to not only diminish the plights of other immigrants, but also to justify or even repeat historical trauma onto them, including treatment that the Irish historically suffered, as seen in the mention of segregation (in the Irish sense) or forced relocation.⁸

The “replacement” ideology extends explicitly to language.

I concur with you totally, it’s a sick county I live in. They said that statistics show that by the year 2011 Espanol will be the main spoken laungage. (HSD: 31688744)

This post, likely created sometime between 2002 and 2010, is suggesting that English will be replaced by Spanish in some county, despite the fact that the opposite occurs – more bilingual Spanish communities are shifting to English monolingualism in the United States. Yet the ideology behind the post hearkens

⁸One poster even muses about expanding racial segregation in classrooms by reversing the tools of integration seen in minority-majority schools.

I want to see Whites bused in there until the Latinos are a 30% minority and not outnumbering the Asians, Blacks and Whites. Where is forced busing when you need it? (HSD: 13209079)

again to the great replacement theory that the diminishment of the language is evidence of the replacement of white people. We see the term “replacement” used explicitly in a post on GHC, where English is viewed not only as a minority language, but incredibly one that needs special protection like Quebecois French.

“Get with the program, racists, and learn Spanish.” The “program”-displacement of Historic American Nation. Quebec-type language laws the only answer (GHC: 23184)

Some posters do not consider speaking English enough, but that immigration of any kind results in the so-called “replacement” of white people, as seen in the post on GHC.

With respect ur 100% wrong we need to be worried about ppl abusing the right wing anti immigration sentiment and moving it into the direction of support for soft multiculturalism. “mass immigration is ok as long as the immigrants speak english and dont rape kids” sentiment tjats wot Tommy stands for its sick. Replacing our ppl is nva ok (GHC: 6973)

White supremacists view a speaker’s race as deterministic in their ability to speak English, as seen in the post below which rattles off a number of activities which the poster associates with white people, and don’t associate with people of color, including speaking English.

I never really thought about it before but I guess bicycling is *primarily a white activity*, kind of like sunbathing, going swimming, playing golf, tennis, attending a social function without a brawl taking place, not smelling like a wild animal in the locker room after a hard workout, and *speaking proper English*. (HSD: 30444129, *emphasis mine*)

In each of these cases, white supremacists reinforce racial barriers in their determination of who can speak English.

3.2 European languages and whiteness

From the quotes so far, it might be easy to assume that white supremacists only promote English monolingualism and English-only ideologies, at the expense of any other language. But that is often not the case. Many on HSD indeed promote learning additional languages.

Raise your kids on more than one language. Apparently young kids pick languages up very quickly. I speak two. So do my kids, and they are 4 & 5. (HSD: 30747632)

It is a good language to learn and is related to all other Slavic languages. [...] (HSD: 13504387)

Other posters on GHC echo these sentiments, which is indicative of the embrace of languages among some far-right extremists.

Read old books. Learn new languages. Good advice. Good article. (GHC: 25192)

If you want to learn a new language, you don't have to move to a foreign country to immerse yourself in the language. You can stay immersed just by reading and listening to it all day no matter where you live. (GHC: 16755)

Often, white supremacists discuss learning their own heritage languages, or those which, for the purposes of this paper, I define as the languages which individuals have ancestral connection to, regardless of whether they grew up hearing the language or not. Such seems to be the case for this poster on Stormfront.

Slowly making my way through a Romanian Bible I got for my birthday in July. Though I am not a Christian, I can read it alongside the English and try to figure out words I don't know. (HSD: 30630091)

Nevertheless, for white supremacists, the only languages worthy of learning are European languages. It is clear from posts in HSD that the white supremacists' motivation for learning languages is often related to their white heritage. We can see this in several examples. First, we see it with a user on Stormfront who was crowdsourcing Danish census terms in order to conduct research on family genealogy.

I would like to finish this tree for posterity, so what about these terms? Kokkepige Stuepige Barnepige Tjenestepige Tienestefolk Huus jomfure (House something?) Politifuldm. Står i butik (papirforretn.) (The above are other people listed as living in my family's home. Servents/maids, workers of some type? Lodgers?) Also: Student, underholdes af faderen (Student of ... ?) Handelsbetjent I really appreciate your help, Profoss. It took me forever to find these documents.... (HSD: 13590117)

Another engages in a discussion about Finno-Ugric (Uralic) folklore and songs.

Please, enough of the Finno-Ugric fairy tale [...] And here is a Khanty song for comparison Khanty song “Akem ar” (“Old Man’s Song”) (HSD: 12872207)

And several others trace etymologies of words in Indo-European languages.⁹

Yup. Here’s a list of some of the other derivatives: Skr. धूम (dhūma), Old Prussian dumis, Russ. дым (dym), Lat. fūmus, Gm. toup/toben, Gk. θυμός (thumos), Toch. twe/tweye, Lith. dūmai, Ltv. dūmi, Eng. dōmian/dusk, Goth. dauns, ON daunn, Ir. dé/deathach, Welsh dywy, Oscan Mefit, Polish dym, Pers. dud, OCS дымъ (dymŭ) (HSD: 30586603)

While the content of this post appears benign, this is nevertheless one poster on Stormfront accessing cognate sets in Indo-European languages. It shows that the tools used by linguists are appropriated by white nationalists, though to what end isn’t clear in this post without more context.

Not every white person using their heritage language is praised.¹⁰ One post expressed disdain for those who use their language but don’t promote white supremacy.

They [the Irish] are a good example of people who are brainwashed. They speak the Irish language because it’s their culture but are brainwashed into thinking that it’s ok to destroy our race. (HSD: 13863902)¹¹

Ireland is run by England/Jews. The Irish make no law or policy. Nor does Sinn Fein Or Ira. (GHC: 2999)

This is one of the few instances where white speakers are criticized, but it is relatively uncommon. Most of white supremacists’ scorn is reserved for the speech of people of color.

And just like how white supremacists only accept white people speaking English, many only accept white people speaking a language originally from Europe.

⁹Other examples include *ingratiate* (HSD: 30734623), *epistrophe* (HSD: 30791003), *lambent* (HSD: 30704903), and Old English and Celtic origins in the surname *Lee* (HSD: 30620846).

¹⁰Indeed, one post from 2018 on GHC expresses disdain for the protection of Irish in Ulster in what appears to be Unionist support of English monolingualism.

PLEASE SIGN THIS PETITION ON BEHALF OF GOD’S PEOPLE IN BRITISH ULSTER NOW UNDER THE THREAT OF A LEPRECHAUN LANGUAGE ACT!!!!!! DON’T LET THE VERMIN GET AWAY WITH CULTURAL GENOCIDE!!!!!! (GHC 3382)

¹¹We see similar kinds of bemoanings rooted in antisemitism in the GHC.

Spanish is NOT their language! It is our (White) language, just like French is our language even though millions of negroes in Africa speak it. (HSD: 30756516)

There's something so gross and such an assault on the senses as the sound of an European romance language coming from the mouths of savages! (HSD: 13384830)

In the post above, white supremacists attribute ownership of both Spanish and French to white people, even though the majority of the speakers of both languages are people of color. And these are the speakers of Romance languages that the white supremacists show disgust for. The latter post does not mention how people of color speak the language, or their varieties or dialects, but rather the posters' animosity seems directed squarely at their race – that people of color have no right to speak the language or aren't even able to speak the language. These posts show that it's not even about language per se, but rather the race of the speaker, regardless of language. White supremacists always punish non-white speakers, whether they speak a European language or a non-European language, and this falls out from intersectionality.¹²

In posts discussing national languages of various countries, this notion of who can and can't speak the language is reinforced, couched in an ideology of linguistic nationalism, not unlike the English-only posts.

[...] For most of the service jobs you definatly have to speak Danish well. So that excludes uneducated third worlders. (HSD: 13591809)

Posters on Stormfront from various countries frequently and forcefully demand that immigrants leave, making explicit their racist appeals to their national language, motivated by white nationalism.

¹²White supremacists even folk theorize that the supposed mutual intelligibility of dialects is determined by the race of the speakers.

Americans and Irish understand each other better than Spaniards and the beaners ... the US and Ireland are the 1st world so they are educated unlike the beaners. (HSD: 30691153)

The poster advances the notion that somehow mutual intelligibility is related to education, but the use of the slur for Hispanics betrays the poster's ideology – that they view race as deterministic for mutual intelligibility. This is rooted in ideologies of dialect and language supremacy, that is multiracial speakers of languages are less likely to understand the “pure” white varieties and vice versa.

everyone who doesnt speak Romanian and look as in WHITE get out of Romania a move back to your homeland. Russians. Hungarians. Gypsies! Jews! Dessert *****!! (HSD: 14077746)

This disturbing post shows how white supremacists view race, language, and nationalism as key components of their racist ideology, where, to this one poster for example, the only acceptable people living in Romania are those who were born in the country, speak the language, are not Jewish or Roma, *and* are white.

This racist ideology parallels how white supremacist view race and nationality, where posters routinely exclude people of color from definitions of who is European and what is their nationality.

In certain circumstances I would agree with you but in Europe by preserving our nations we are preserving our race as well because there is no way a black in Europe can be British, Irish, German or whatever. (HSD: 13859163)

This reinforces their racist distinction of Europeanness and non-Europeanness (Rosa & Flores 2017), where the criteria is some unarticulated notion of ancestral heritage which gatekeeps those who can and can't speak a language. Not only is this a co-naturalization of race and language, within their theory, but seemingly one where white supremacists view the capacity to speak a language as one which is inherited genetically.

Just like in the English-only context, white supremacists often view other languages in their country as some twisted form of evidence of their 'replacement.' Metapedia articles consistently reiterate this ideology. In the article on the Arabic language, it states:

[...] Arabic is the language of the Quran and the religious language of all Muslims, therefore having been spread in association with Islamization of various areas. (Metapedia: *Arabic language*)

The authors of the article first conflate Classical Arabic of the Quran with Modern Arabic. Notwithstanding, the article then bizarrely associates the use of the language as evidence of Islamization, which is frequently found in their replacement discourses.

For white nationalists, it is always the linguistic replacement of European languages, ever the victims. We see the same kind of perspective in another Metapedia article, but this time with a German dialect.

[...] in the French regions of Alsace and Lorraine French has *replaced* the local German dialects as the official language, even though it has *not been fully replaced* on the street. [...] Some German-speaking communities still survive in parts of Romania, the Czech Republic, Hungary, and above all Russia and Kazakhstan, although *forced expulsions* after World War II and *massive emigration* to Germany in the 1980s and 1990s have depopulated most of these communities. (Metapedia: *German language*, emphasis mine)

Within these white nationalist discourses, Germans are often portrayed as the ultimate victims, which is consistent with the proliferation of Holocaust denialism on each of these platforms, and thus the article insinuates that endangerment of this dialect, even by other European languages, is indicative of the replacement of Germanic people.

White supremacists frequently elevate German and Germanic languages, as seen in a nauseating Metapedia article on Nordicism, where the article authors tie racial and linguistic supremacy with Germanic peoples.

[...] The concept of a reborn “Germanic” or “Nordic” race is a leitmotif of those who fear the downfall of the European race. Like in the first part of the nineteenth century, discussions on the origin and identity of the *Germanic peoples nation* are once again dominated by historians, *linguists*, and folklorists. [...] The idea of a psychic unity of humankind has been exposed as a leftist political agenda. Every year thousands board rickety boats, hide in the backs of trucks, planes, and container ships, cross miles of barren desert on foot ... All to get themselves to a land where they can be ruled by a racial group far distant from their own. While it’s not clear what mix of genes/*language/culture* has permeated the Germanic space, we have to draw lines somewhere. We consider ‘Teutonic’ all the descendents of NW European *Germanic language speakers*, including all of the British Isles and their offspring-states, Scandinavia (with Finland), Germany, Austria, and Benelux. (We do not include South Africa, as even though it was built and maintained by Teutons, the reins of power have now been passed to others.) Though we are always told that the global ‘South’ wants to migrate to the ‘North,’ the reality is more nuanced. Hundreds of millions of people from the third world would like very much to live under the rule of a Teutonic people. (Metapedia: *Nordicism #History*, emphasis mine)

The discussion of using linguistics to reconstruct Proto-Germanic for some kind of Nordacist cause shows how the field of linguistics has been weaponized

by white nationalists. The appeal to some kind of modern 'Teutonic' people is a clear emblem of a delusional mythical past used to both define and justify the hegemonic position of various countries with Germanic official languages or lingua francas. Their exclusion of South Africa from this label is an apparent allusion to the end of apartheid and rise of a multiracial democracy in the country, which is viewed in the article as a loss for Germanic people.

We see the same kind of racism on GHC, where languages (as well as countries) are viewed as inherently white, which is the perceived source for their high value and demand across the world.

All races want to breed with Whites, live in White countries, learn White languages, adopt our looks, our mannerisms, our NAMES. Love us, fuck us, kill us, live with us. Love/hate is a powerful combo, on the other hand all Whites want is some space to ourselves! (GHC: 17089)

This post also observes and justifies the hegemonic position of white people and then used against people of color.

3.3 Minority and endangered languages and whiteness

We see many instances where white nationalists view that nationalism, heritage, race, and languages are co-extensive, which is exemplified in the following post on GHC.

Also useful for understanding the requirements of nationhood: common religion, common blood, common language, common culture (GHC: 290)

But critically they also see minority European languages as under threat, especially to larger languages or globalization.

I would think that European nationalist organizations would be easier to create than American nationalist organizations. White Irish nationalist for Ireland White German nationalist for Germany White Dutch people for the Netherlands That's not hard borders are very important even between European countries *To destroy or harm any culture is a crime against humanity and melting down all the smaller countries into one big country destroying their languages* and so on would just be wrong, we should work together yes we are all white and all brothers and our nations are sacred. (HSD: 12860520, emphasis mine)

Thus, white nationalists are concerned about minority languages to some extent, but when that's the case, it is for European minority languages. In doing so, these posters espouse white supremacist ideologies, but at the same time, portray white people as the victims.

We also see some concern among white nationalists on language and dialect endangerment, but again only European languages and dialects. We see this precise concern in the Metapedia article on *Constructed language*, though in the same breath, it still justifies the hegemony of national languages or lingua francas.

Thus, for example, many dialects and small languages are gradually disappearing, but not due to competition from constructed languages, but due to competition from larger natural languages [...] Even if arguing for that every language and dialect should be preserved, then in international communications the parties will still usually communicate using some particular language that both parties understand." (Metapedia: *Constructed language*)

White nationalists also lament the death of languages, but again only of European languages, and in this case, an ancient one, as conveyed with the initial adverbial.

Unfortunately, all of the Eastern Germanic languages went extinct starting in the 4th century, and the last living language of this branch died in the late 18th century. (Metapedia: *Germanic languages*)

Concerns about language endangerment within white supremacist spaces likely parallel racist narratives of "white genocide," as exemplified in the following post.

Yah it is sad to see and if the Irish dont quash it soon the last of the Kelts will be gone from the world." (HSD: 13852977)

Among white nationalists, there are pushes toward restoring and reclaiming this mythical past. As we see time and time again, their call for this historical and cultural reclamation entails the removal of anyone outside those who white supremacists define as their heritage.

The Europeans Saxons, vikings, celts, normans, goths, vandals, romans, franks and many other European tribes need to come back to life, and reclaim there country, and culture before we no longer have a history or country we can call home. (GHC: 16802)

This sort of hearkening to a mythical past is constantly reinforced by white supremacist ideologies, as we see in the following post about Gaulish warriors:

Ever noticed how they always say that about the Romans or Greek armies ... No one says “oh I wonder how many non Whites were on the Goth or Gaul armies” (HSD: 14060956)

This brings me to the principal case study of this paper. In one sub-forum on Stormfront Ireland, a poster discusses printing leaflets.

I would like to get some of the leaflets printed and distribute them but sadly I have not got the funds. (HSD: 13642982)

The next post sampled in that subforum provides context for the event that the leaflets are being printed.

With the help of God we will be congratulating an Irish WN Party on their election success in the not so distant future. 88 (HSD: 13842729)

When white nationalists, abbreviated in the post as “WN,” discuss printing “leaflets” on Stormfront, they mean white supremacist literature. It is not clear which Irish election they are referring to, but posts in this corpus range from 2002 to 2017.

There are a number of subsequent posts within this subforum on the Irish election and politics. Eventually, another user brings up how to type in the Irish orthography, responding, at first, in an anglicized Scottish Gaelic.

*Latha math dhuibh agus dè tha dol agad fhèin, a Phàdruig*¹³ [...] *Aye, warrior of Éire*¹⁴ ... whether you would like *fadas*¹⁵ for *Irish Gæilge*, e.g., é, í, ó and the like, or *Scottish Gælick*, e.g., ì, ò, è, é, í, à, ù and the like ... try such, lad: “I. Start Menu to All Programs to Accessouries to System Tools to *Litrichean*¹⁶ (I *canæ* re-call of what Litrichean tis called in English for my computer is in *Gàidhlig*,¹⁷ but tis Script Lettres, Characters or the like, I reckon.) You shall know of where to go from there, *gille*.¹⁸ or ... II. Change the language of

¹³Scottish Gaelic: *Good day to you (hon.) and what's going on with you, Patrick (voc.)*

¹⁴Irish: *Ireland*

¹⁵Scottish Gaelic and Irish: *diacritics*

¹⁶Scottish Gaelic: *letters*

¹⁷Scottish Gaelic: *Gaelic*

¹⁸Scottish Gaelic: *lad*

your keyboard setting in your Control Panel under the Regional Optional and Languages theme. or ... III. Make a visit here, lad ...¹⁹ or ... IV. *Pray vnto Odin*. Many-a-luck to you, *gille*. (HSD: 13868014, emphasis mine)

The post on Stormfront, which code-switches frequently between English, Scottish Gaelic, and Irish, explains how to install Irish orthography on a keyboard, in response to someone printing leaflets for an upcoming election. This is one instance of white supremacists appropriating the language revitalization of Irish and Gaelic for the production of white supremacist literature.²⁰

The “Pray vnto Odin” salutation is a nod to white supremacists’ appropriation of Norse paganism (Pollard 2016) and Nordicism. In that vein, Wilson (2021: 249) noted that:

Post-war fascists have also sought to bring about a revolutionary consciousness through the development of religio-political forms. Notable among them for its influence within the milieu, the quasi-Nordic Wotansvolk. [...] Its racialism characterizes Wotansvolk as a “blood religion” in which “the folk” – and its purity – is central to the collective credo.

¹⁹Here, an external URL is provided.

²⁰A reviewer for a conference presentation of this paper observed “the construction of Irish orthography as ‘white’ is surprising given that Irish immigrants in the US were previously not racialized as white.” However, it is important to reiterate that this forum is a global venue for white supremacists. Many posts on Irish are specifically from the ‘Stormfront Ireland’ subforum. US history of Irish racialization is not appropriate lens for racism in Ireland and is arguably not even a good lens to understand contemporary racism in the US.

In fact, some white supremacists argue against distinguishing the relative whiteness of different nationalities, as is characteristic of historical anti-Irish, anti-Italian, and anti-Polish discrimination, but instead white supremacists in HSD appear to have mostly recast the debate between white and non-white, as seen in the following posts.

I find it funny that people here spend their time trying to figure out if Spaniards, Ukrainians, Portuguese, Italians, and Russians are white enough. (HSD: 14666376)

Meds are not superior, neither are Nordics, Germans are not better than Slavs, neither are Slavs better than Celts. Stop this BS. Our enemies want us ALL dead, regardless of which White tribe/region we belong to. (GHC: 1736)

To the extent that any white nationalist hold any white group as superior to another is usually a promotion of their own heritage rather than in disparaging another.

Germanic, Scandinavian, Scottish! Best of the white race! Scottish temper with Germanic and Scandinavian build! Gotta love it! LOL 😂 (GHC: 16959)

The Slavic race is superior!! (GHC: 831)

Wilson (2021) similarly discusses the appropriation and contortion of Wicca and Celtic Druidism by white supremacists.²¹ The use of ⟨v⟩ in the word *vnto* is often a marker of white supremacy and Aryanism, as seen in the name of the now-defunct white nationalist group *Identity Evropa*.

The notion of someone responding in Scottish Gaelic to a post about an Irish election is an appeal to a broader pan-Celtic white supremacist solidarity. Other similar uses of European languages to appeal to a pan-European white supremacism is found on HSD.

Why not have it so every flyer has all the White languages on it (in small print), yet have their native language in large print once on the top of the other translations, then once below it. Just to show all Whites should have one common goal. Unity. (HSD: 14417871)

This poster reinforces a notion of Europeanness which excludes people of color. The mention of both the local language and a pluralism of other European languages, the so-called “White languages,” show how white nationalists racialize language.

The revitalization of the Scottish Gaelic language has been analyzed as a *culturally* nationalist project (McEwan-Fujita 1997). Similarly, Irish language revitalization has been associated with Irish nationalism and republicanism (Zenker 2012). However, the appropriation and weaponization of the revitalization of these two languages by white supremacists hasn't been well-documented and largely ignored.

²¹Many other Celtic elements are appropriated by white supremacists. For example, Celtic symbols, like the Celtic cross, have been famously appropriated by white supremacists, notably the KKK. Metapedia even acknowledges that the Celtic cross is “used by some nationalist groups stating a relationship with Celts” and “some more general White nationalist groups” (Metapedia, *Celtic cross*).

Moreover, we see Celtic mythology appropriated by white supremacists.

I honestly don't care about this desert rat BS. I am a CELT! Heil LUGH! (GHC: 19938)

The poster exclaims pride in being a “Celt,” and then uses the Nazi interjection with the Irish mythological figure Lugh. As such, the poster indexes their white supremacism through the proclamation of their pride of Celtic heritage.

Lastly, white nationalists list Celtic music among their preferences.

[...] Listen to Bluegrass, Celtic, Texas Swing, Rock a Billy, old time County, Southern Rock, and White Nationalist music! [...] (HSD: 30383102)

This filth is a sectarian British song not an Irish folk song the sort of scum who wrote and admire this filth have no place on a WN forum yet alone an Irish forum (HSD: 13857116)

Historically, some famous Irish language activists, notably Gearóid Ó Cuinneagáin, were fascists aligned with the Axis to resist the UK. Ó Cuinneagáin founded *Ailtirí na hAiséirghe* and used “language classes” as a guise to organize fascist meetings.

Another Celtic language, Breton (in Brittany), has received more attention in this regard. It is well-documented that Nazi Germany collaborated with fascist Breton groups in Brittany, like *Emsav*, during WWII. The Nazis promised support for Breton independence from France in exchange for an alliance with the Axis (Leach 2010). The alliance was not just a military and political one but was also philosophical as it adopted and adapted Nazi white supremacist ideology for a greater pan-Celtic solidarity and supremacy (Leach 2010).

Some early key Breton language revitalization activists were Nazi collaborators (Leach 2010, Boomgaard 2008). Some of these Breton language activists include Célestin Lainé, Olier Mordrel, and Roparz Hemon. Célestin Lainé led *Bezen Perrot*, the SS affiliated militia in Brittany, which was named after a Breton language activist and Nazi sympathizer Jean-Marie Perrot (Leach 2008). Lainé later fled to Ireland to avoid prosecution (Leach 2010). Olier Mordrel was a professor of Celtic languages and founder of the *Breton National Party*, which was later disbanded because of its connection to the Third Reich. Both Lainé and Mordrel broadened the racist notion of Nordicism to include all Celto-Germanic groups (Leach 2010). Perhaps the most influential to Breton activism and revitalization was Roparz Hemon, who was also accused of being a Nazi collaborator. He was sentenced to prison but instead exiled to Ireland. He continued to publish on Breton linguistics in Ireland and his grammar and dictionary are still considered authoritative within Breton linguistics.

In the aftermath of WWII, the Breton movement democratized over time and now largely embodies left-leaning ideologies, just like Scottish and Welsh nationalism,²² which is fairly common among sub-state nationalism (Alessio 2015). Nevertheless, the history of the appropriation of Breton language activism by Nazi collaborators still casts a shadow over genuine progress of its current revitalization (Hornsby & Quentel 2013, Hornsby et al. 2021).

²²In a more contemporary Welsh context, the now-defunct Welsh Defense League (WDL), sometimes called the Cymru Defense League, has received attention in the scholarship (Alessio 2015). Founded in 2009, it was an Islamophobic group whose leadership had ties to many different Neo-Nazi and Aryan white supremacist groups and it used violent means. Nevertheless, it did not grow much, as Welsh nationalism is largely left leaning, dominated by the Labour and Plaid political parties, and inherently tied to the Welsh language and opposed to creeping monolingual English-speaking groups. This contrasts with the WDL, who viewed Muslims and immigrants as threats. Indeed, the WDL and many of its successors have been more English-speaking and largely pro-British and Unionist (Alessio 2015).

3.4 Consequences

One poster makes explicit why language is important to white supremacists in their discussion of raising children, which reveals the sheer sinister nature of their goals.

Our youth are our future indeed! Just as Hitler's youth ours must be addressed early to the doctrines in order to secure a fundamental inherent belief system which corresponds within a timely manner enabling them and thier thought processes to formulate and adjust to rudimentary belief functions incorporating all thier senses. They must become keenly aware of social agendas and political ramifications of action vs. inaction as it pertains to strategical logistics of a growing super power. Home schooling if feesible since, they must not only master the social sciences etc ... but als be able to be profiecent in the arts including music theory. Social skills and graces along w/public speaking. Weapon, hunting, survival, building, self-defense, explosives/bomb making & deactivation, codes, languages, counterintelligence, interogation, re-programing/minds and above all else always behave as a little kid! Gotchya-this can all be accomplished through father and son/daughter communication starting at a young age and progressing untill the late teen years following dads clues/guidance. Learned behavior-especially since children tend to emulate the role model and mold them 'selves accordingly to thier parent of whom they love very much and want to please. [...] (HSD: 14417601, emphasis mine)

This poster first begins with a sort of roadmap for white supremacists' parents raising their children, appealing to philosophies of hate propagated by Adolf Hitler and the so-called "14 words."²³ Recognizing the impressionability of children, this post discusses white supremacists' agenda of indoctrinating children with racist and violent ideologies early in their life. The poster suggests that much of this can be done in the home and therefore suggests home schooling, likely to exert total control over the instruction and prevent any influence from public school systems. The poster then lists a number of skills and expertise valued by white supremacists for their violent ends of white supremacy. However, many of these cannot be attained in white supremacist home-schooling environments since they involve socialization with others as well as skills that they can't learn from their parents. One of these are languages, disturbingly placed in an array of other skills like "weapons," "explosives," and "re-programming of minds."

²³<https://www.adl.org/resources/hate-symbol/14-words>

The reinforcement of “behaving as a little kid” and everything thereafter highlights both the indoctrination and suppression of children while being taught these skills, all for the advancement of white supremacist causes. This seemingly involves infantilization of the children as they grow and into teenage and young adult years. The posts make clear that it is the goal of raising and indoctrinating new generations of white supremacists that will continue their legacies of violence and hatred.

Are they successful? There is considerable evidence that many are, when we consider the rising hate crimes and terrorism. Moreover, posts on Stormfront also confirm this.

i am a 16yr old irish male dont worry lads i ll make sure ireland stays white and i hope i can count on help from my stormfront brothers around the world???? [...] (HSD: 13864391)

This poster, in his commitment to “make sure Ireland stays white” is responding to calls for younger generations to continue on the legacy of white supremacism, violence, and hatred.

Why is there all this interest in languages? For one, learning languages are seen as opportunities in the spread of far-right ideologies, especially along the lines of heritage.

By talking German the white Americans can better communicate with their white ethnic German cousins in Germany and bridge the gap. Even communication between English people and Germans may be improved – share political ideas in German. (GHC: 16042)

Further, a common use of international white supremacist spaces, like Stormfront, is for offers and requests for language and translation assistance from speakers of different languages, either for literature or in preparation of planned events and demonstrations. We can see that in the following post.

You can ask to your french fellow in stormfront french part for a little help both of them speak english and french. (HSD: 30782282)

Different language communities have separate subforums on Stormfront, where these requests are made. Surprisingly, perhaps, there is also a subforum for Latin America on Stormfront, where one white supremacist referred another for help on translating literature.

I've posted a thread in Stormfront Latin to help spread the WNPS and too see if we can get more translations. (HSD: 13463194)

This is indicative of a larger agenda of white supremacists. Southern Poverty Law Center (2022) has profiled individuals key to white supremacist movements, such as American white supremacist Gary Lauck, who translates and publishes white supremacist literature and propaganda and smuggles into countries which ban the material. He has translated material into nine languages and successfully smuggled it into twenty-nine other countries, upwards of 8 million pieces per year into Germany alone.

4 Conclusion

In this chapter, we have seen that white supremacists have sought to punish every departure of the constructed white straight male native speaker standard. Posters constantly reinforce a notion of Europeanness, based in a mythical history, but one who is under attack from and being replaced by non-white people who do not speak the national language. Some view minority and endangered European languages as also being the victims of this replacement.

A major research question in this paper was what languages do white supremacists use and view as “for whites only”? From this corpus, we see that white supremacists only accept Indo-European and Uralic languages. But for either, they only accept branches of the families native to Europe. Moreover, they only consider white “native” speakers, above all else, as legitimate speakers of European languages or white people who have heritage to the languages. They don't consider immigrants or people of color as legitimate speakers of these languages, and they don't accept immigrants or people of colors' own native or heritage languages. White supremacists view the speakers' race and ethnicity as deterministic of whether the speaker can and should speak a European language, as if it is only an inherited trait. However, they promote learning other languages, as long as they are languages native to Europe and as long as the learners are white. They also advocate for minority and/or endangered European languages and dialects, but in ways consistent with their white supremacist ideologies, such as connecting with some mythical heritage based in racism. Ultimately, their ideology has more to do with race of the speaker than even what language or variety is spoken.

For linguists, language instructors, and language activists, what can we do with this information? We need to monitor white supremacists' networks. We

need to understand how white supremacists appropriate and weaponize heritage languages, minority languages, endangered languages, and language revitalization, and that there are these dark subcultures among European language activists. Moreover, we need to be vigilant of how white supremacist consume and twist findings of comparative and historical linguistics for their racist means. We need to recognize the origins of these ideologies and how they seep into mainstream. We need to be cognizant of linguistic pseudoscience and folk theory, especially that which is rooted in racism, and actively expose it and combat it. We need to recognize that not everyone involved with language learning or linguistics share the same benign values or intentions. Finally, we need to include lessons of language or dialect discrimination into pedagogy, with a specific inclusion of minoritized varieties.

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